NEW WAVE FROM THE NORTHEAST

POWERFUL FILMS FROM THE REGION ARE FINALLY GETTING THE ATTENTION THEY DESERVE IN INDIA AND BEYOND, OVERCOMING FUNDING ROADBLOCKS

By **Suhani Singh**



ALL THROUGH HER CHILDHOOD, Tribeny Rai wondered why she didn't see someone who looked like her on any screen, big or small. Only in 2007, when Darjeeling's Prashant Tamang made it to *Indian Idol*, did Rai's family, like many in her Sikkimese village of Nandok, get a cable connection to follow his exploits in the reality contest. Still, Rai's sense of Sikkimese films remained weak. She recalls watching only two Nepali-language films in Gangtok's two single-screen cinemas.

As a consequence, when the Satyajit Ray Film & Television Institute of India (SRFTI) alumna began writing *Shape of Momo* a few years back, she ensured the protagonist was one she related with. "We are mostly complaining about how we are misrepresented or underrepresented," she says. "If you want to be the hero of your story, you should take the reins in your hand. If you want to bring about change, you have to do it yourself."

On May 29, Rana Daggubati's Spirit Media released *Shape of Momo* in 15 cities across India, including metros and Nepali-speaking centres like Darjeeling, Kalimpong (West Bengal) and Namchi (Sikkim). Set in Nandok, with Rai's family house serving as a prime location, the acclaimed drama offers a compelling portrait of a thirtysomething woman who returns to her ancestral home after life in Delhi and struggles to fit into what she sees as a patriarchal world. But *Shape of Momo* isn't the only film from the Northeast to attract the national spotlight this year. Laxmipriya Devi's Manipuri film *Boong*, about a Meitei boy (played by the Kuki-Zo actor Gugun Kipgen) who goes looking for his missing father in Myanmar, got a re-release across India after winning a BAFTA (The British Academy Film Awards). "To walk up till here felt like the last few steps to reach a summit of a mountain we never knew we were climbing in the first place," said Devi,

